

Moving Company Startup Costs: Real Numbers From Real Owners

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Moving Company Startup Costs: Real Numbers From Real Owners

Starting a moving company has lower barriers than most service businesses of comparable earning potential. But "lower barriers" doesn't mean "no costs." The operators who survive the first year are the ones who planned their costs honestly before spending a dollar.

The Two Categories of Cost

One-time startup costs: What you spend to get operational. These are mostly equipment.

Ongoing monthly costs: What you spend to stay operational. These determine your break-even point.

One-Time Startup Costs

The Truck(s)

Your biggest decision — and the one with the most options.

Box truck (16 to 26 foot):

- New: \$45,000 to \$80,000
- Used (100,000 to 200,000 miles): \$15,000 to \$35,000
- Used (200,000+ miles, higher risk): \$8,000 to \$18,000

The sweet spot for a new operator: a used 24-foot box truck with 100,000 to 150,000 miles in good condition. Budget \$18,000 to \$28,000. Get a pre-purchase inspection (\$150 to \$300) from a diesel mechanic — mandatory, not optional.

What to look for: Clean body (rust on the box is more cosmetic; rust on the frame is structural), working lift gate, functioning air conditioning (for summer moves), clean maintenance history, functional hydraulics on the lift gate.

Cargo van (for smaller moves):

If you're starting with smaller apartment and studio moves, a cargo van is a lower-cost entry. Used Transit or ProMaster vans run \$15,000 to \$25,000 used. Lower capacity, but also lower operating cost. Many operators start with a van and a pickup/trailer, then graduate to a box truck when volume justifies it.

Moving Equipment

This is non-negotiable. Showing up to a move without proper equipment damages furniture, injures crew, and kills your reviews.

Equipment Item	Cost
Moving blankets (set of 12)	\$80 – \$150
Furniture dollies (2 to 4)	\$30 – \$60 each
Appliance dolly (hand truck)	\$80 – \$200
Stair-climbing dolly	\$200 – \$400
Moving straps (4 to 6 sets)	\$20 – \$40 per set
Stretch wrap (several rolls)	\$30 – \$60

Equipment Item	Cost
Floor runners / carpet protection	\$50 – \$150
Door frame protection	\$50 – \$100
Total equipment starter kit	\$700 – \$1,500

Add to this a basic toolkit for disassembly/reassembly (beds, furniture with hardware): \$100 to \$300.

Business Setup

Item	Cost
LLC formation	\$100 – \$800 (varies by state)
Business bank account	\$0 – \$50
Website (basic)	\$0 – \$2,000
Business cards and basic marketing materials	\$100 – \$300
Uniforms (t-shirts with logo for crew)	\$200 – \$500 for initial set

DOT and Regulatory Requirements

For intrastate (in-state only) moves:

- USDOT number: Free
- State carrier registration: \$50 to \$500 depending on state
- Business license: \$50 to \$500 depending on city/county

For interstate (crossing state lines):

- FMCSA Operating Authority (MC number): \$300
- BOC-3 filing (process agent): \$30 to \$75
- UCR registration: \$60 to \$80/year
- IFTA fuel tax registration: Free in most states

If you plan to do long-distance moves from day one, budget an extra \$500 to \$800 for regulatory setup and allow 4 to 6 weeks for FMCSA processing.

Total One-Time Startup Costs

Scenario	Equipment	Total
Lean start (used van + basic equipment)	\$15,000 – \$25,000	\$18,000 – \$28,000
Standard start (used 24-ft truck)	\$20,000 – \$35,000	\$23,000 – \$40,000
Strong start (newer used truck, full equipment)	\$30,000 – \$50,000	\$35,000 – \$58,000

Ongoing Monthly Costs

Insurance — The Non-Negotiable

Moving company insurance is more complex and more expensive than most operators expect.

Required coverages:

Coverage	Monthly Cost
Commercial auto (the truck)	\$300 – \$700/month
General liability (\$1M minimum)	\$150 – \$400/month
Cargo liability (for customers' belongings)	\$100 – \$300/month
Workers' compensation (if you have employees)	\$200 – \$600/month per employee
Total insurance (1 truck, no employees)	\$550 – \$1,400/month

2026 note: Insurance rates have increased 15 to 25% since 2022 for commercial auto and cargo liability in the moving industry. Claims frequency and severity have both increased. Get multiple quotes — rates vary dramatically between carriers.

Never skip cargo liability. This is what pays when your crew breaks a customer's flat screen or damages an antique. Without it, one bad claim can bankrupt a new business.

Truck Operating Costs

Cost Item	Monthly (1 Truck)
Fuel (200 miles/day, 5 days/week, \$3.80/gal)	\$1,500 – \$2,200
Maintenance reserve	\$400 – \$800
Truck payment (if financed)	\$500 – \$1,200
Tires (annualized monthly)	\$80 – \$150

Labor

This is your biggest ongoing cost. For a 2-person crew:

Labor Item	Cost
2 movers at \$16 – \$22/hr for 8-hour day	\$256 – \$352/day
At 5 days/week, 4 weeks/month	\$5,120 – \$7,040/month
Payroll taxes (employer portion, ~15%)	\$768 – \$1,056/month
Total labor (2 crew) per month	\$5,888 – \$8,096/month

Note on fuel reality check: Many startup guides list \$1,500 to \$2,200/month in fuel for a moving truck. That figure assumes 200 miles per operating day — which is freight trucking, not local moving. A local moving truck averages 40 to 80 miles per operating day, staying within a 20 to 30-mile service radius. Realistic monthly fuel budget for a single truck at 5 days/week: **\$400 to \$900/month** depending on your market geography.

Supplies

Budget \$25 to \$50 per job for consumables (tape, stretch wrap, floor runners, boxes if providing them). At 20 jobs per month: \$500 to \$1,000/month.

Marketing

What you spend on marketing depends on your approach:

- **Pay-per-move:** \$0 upfront, success fee per completed job (~10 to 15%)
- **Google Ads:** \$500 to \$2,000/month
- **Agency retainer:** \$1,500 to \$4,000/month
- **DIY (your time + tools):** \$100 to \$300/month

Summary: Monthly Operating Costs (1 Truck, 2-Person Crew)

Item	Low	High
Insurance	\$550	\$1,400
Fuel	\$1,500	\$2,200
Maintenance	\$400	\$800

Item	Low	High
Truck payment	\$500	\$1,200
Labor (2 crew)	\$5,888	\$8,096
Supplies	\$500	\$1,000
Marketing	\$500	\$2,000
Overhead (software, phone, admin)	\$200	\$500
Total Monthly Operating Cost	\$10,038	\$17,196

Your Break-Even Job Count

At \$10,038/month in costs and \$800 average job revenue:

- **Break-even: 12 to 13 jobs per month**

At \$17,196/month in costs:

- **Break-even: 21 to 22 jobs per month**

To pay yourself \$5,000/month on top of costs:

- **Target: 18 to 28 jobs per month** depending on your cost structure

That's 4 to 7 jobs per week — entirely achievable with one truck and consistent marketing.

How Long Until You're Profitable?

Month 1 to 2: Getting operational, building systems, first customers. Usually not profitable.

Month 3 to 4: Reviews building, word-of-mouth starting, reaching break-even.

Month 5 to 6: Consistent volume, first month of real profitability.

Month 12+: Considering second truck, possibly hiring dispatcher.

The operators who reach profitability fastest are the ones who treat marketing as seriously as operations from day one.

Want to model the numbers for your specific market? Book a free strategy call and we'll show you what break-even looks like in your area.